

DESIGNER

BALENCIAGA

A private man, monastically dedicated to the pursuit of perfection, Cristóbal Balenciaga let his dramatic, fluid clothes speak for him. Although lauded less than Dior, he anticipated aspects of the New Look, headed the most exclusive Paris *maison* in the immediate post-war era through the 1950s, helped create 1960s garment shapes, and most importantly invented a totally new silhouette for women.

Balenciaga had a legendary talent for cut, seaming, and finish. He understood how fabric draped and how the stiff materials he loved dictated sculptural shapes. Born in a fishing village in Basque Spain, the young Balenciaga absorbed a great deal from his mother, a dressmaker to local wealthy women. In his early teens, a local aristocrat, who later became both patron and client, helped him secure a superior tailoring apprenticeship.

The move to Paris

By his early 20s, Balenciaga had a boutique in the fashionable Spanish seaside resort of San Sebastián. Branches in Madrid and Barcelona followed as he became Spain's leading couturier. The Spanish Civil War triggered a move to Paris, where by 1937 he established himself in style at avenue Georges V. Soon after Balenciaga arrived in Paris, the city hailed him as a major presence. He created a series of distinctive shapes, often waistless and loose, that magically seemed both independent of the body and in harmony with the female form. The mature women who made up a large part of his wealthy clientele found his clothes especially flattering.

His first runway show referred to the Spanish Renaissance, and his collections drew on his country's culture and past. He put bustles on evening gowns. The 1939 hourglass *Infanta* gown sprang from Velázquez's

paintings. The traditional female dress and religious vestments of Spain, and other Spanish artists such as Zurbarán, inspired dramatic dark garments. Bolero jackets and capes echoed toreadors' outfits, while short-fronted, long-backed garments recalled flamenco dresses.

Down to essentials

Balenciaga pared down his elegant lines in the 1950s. His part-tight, part-loose garments, such as jackets with a fitted front and billowing back, introduced around 1951, created a revolution in fashion. His straight, loose sack dress (1957) prefigured simple 1960s shapes. There were also flounced, trapezoid baby doll dresses with wide waists (1957 and 58), balloon jackets and skirts, cocoon coats, and empire-line gowns. Stand-away collars lengthened the neck, big buttons added bold detail, and seven-eighths-length sleeves revealed women's bracelets. Sleeves were an obsession. Balenciaga remade any, sometimes on the wearer, that did not lie perfectly. He was adept at tricky dolman-style sleeves, cut as a piece with the garment body.

The 1960s brought bold experiments with fabric. Balenciaga developed a stiff silk called silk Gazaar with Abraham's fabric house and also used transparent materials and plastic rainwear. He further refined the linearity that now dominated fashion. Despite producing some of his most exciting work in this decade, Balenciaga was perhaps out of step with new mass-market values and he closed his couture house in 1968. After a stagnant period and acquisition by Gucci, his love of shape lives on with Nicolas Ghesquière's designs for the Balenciaga brand. Courrèges and Ungaro, both Balenciaga apprentices, and Givenchy, were all influenced by their mentor. So were Mila Schön, with her expert tailoring, and Oscar de la Renta, with details like sash bows on evening gowns.



△ **CRISTOBAL BALENCIAGA 1927**

Dubbed the "Picasso of fashion" for his artistic innovations with shape and form, Balenciaga was among few couturiers capable of making a haute couture garment from scratch himself.

◁ **EVENING DRESS 1946**

Balenciaga loved and understood material — hence his cleverly draped gowns like this one, reminiscent of flamenco costume. Aside from black, red and pink were favourite colours.

TIMELINE

1895 Born in Guetaria, Spain

1917 Establishes first dressmaking business in San Sebastián

1936–37 Civil war prompts move to Paris. Shows first collection for Autumn 1937

1939 Introduces *Infanta* silhouette

1947 Creates more voluminous Barrel line

1950s ▷ Designs extravagant evening gowns. Introduces rollaway collars, slimline tunics, and sack dresses

1960s Experiments with bold shapes, wool capes, plastic rainwear, and transparent fabrics

1968 Designs Air France uniform. Fashion house closes. Balenciaga retires

1972 Dies in Valencia, Spain

1997 Fashion house fortunes revive when Nicolas Ghesquière is made design principal

2006 ▷ Actress Nicole Kidman wears Balenciaga at the Academy Awards in Hollywood

2001 Gucci Group buys Balenciaga brand (now ready-to-wear)

